across the river and along its right bank. Like the river, the trajectory followed by the settlement was linear. Some time at the beginning of recorded history, around the sixth century BCE, 300 years or so before Ashoka was born, a settlement stood in the area which the sprawling city of Patna has now overtaken, a little after the confluence of the Son river with the Ganga. We know this because surviving traces of that first settlement contain the archetypal deluxe pottery of that time, the North Black Polished Ware—so called because a lot of this pottery is usually a shiny black and has been found in many parts of North India.[8] This early settlement was also the one where the Buddha, on his last journey from the state of Magadha, is said to have stayed. Pataligrama was what it was called then, suggesting its origins in a village (‘grama’). There he apparently addressed his devotees in a council hall before crossing the Ganga towards Vaishali.[9]

While sojourning in its vicinity the Buddha is reported as having seen thousands of magical creatures haunting Pataligrama. This he interpreted as a sign that a fortress was being built. The intuition was confirmed by his disciple, Ananda, who told him that the chief ministers of Magadha—the capital of which was located further south, around Rajagriha—were building a fortress to better defend themselves against the Vajji state.

Unlike monarchical Magadha, the Vajjis were a republican political confederacy which dominated a region that stretched beyond the left bank of the Ganga, in the vicinity of Basarh. Seeing this construction as the influence of powerful ‘fairies’ who ‘bend the hearts of the most powerful kings and ministers to build dwelling-places’, the Buddha is believed to have made a prophecy about the future of Pataliputra to his disciple: ‘And as far, Ananda, as Aryan people resort, as far as merchants travel, this will become the chief city, Patali-putta, a centre of the interchange of all kinds of wares. But three dangers will hang over Patali-putta, that of fire, that of water, and that of dissension among friends.’[10] The Buddha is, essentially, evoked in the early Buddhist literature for every event or occurrence that